

Message-Passing Graph Neural Network as a Surrogate for Variable-Length 1D Finite Element Bead Chain Simulations

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Abstract

Finite element analysis (FEA) of a flexible bead chain requires thousands of force and integration computations per simulated second. We train a graph neural network (GNN) to predict the per-timestep physics of a 1D bead chain with tapered mass, using randomly sampled single-step training data instead of recorded simulations. An initial shared MLP achieved accurate predictions on a fixed 16-bead chain but could not generalize to other lengths. We restructure the surrogate as a true message-passing GNN with separate node/edge encoders, learned messages per rod, and ghost masking for endpoints. Because all weights are shared, one trained model handles chains of any length.

Problem Setup

A whip is modeled as a 1D chain of N tapered mass nodes connected by $N - 1$ spring rods, anchored at one end. Each free bead experiences gravity, Hookean spring forces, rod-axis damping, and velocity drag. Time integration uses symplectic Euler:

$$\mathbf{v}_i^{n+1} = \mathbf{v}_i^n + \Delta t \mathbf{a}(\mathbf{x}^n) \tag{1}$$

$$\mathbf{x}_i^{n+1} = \mathbf{x}_i^n + \Delta t \mathbf{v}_i^{n+1} \tag{2}$$

The force on bead i depends only on its state and those of its immediate neighbors. This locality is why we use a 1-hop graph architecture.

MPGNN Architecture

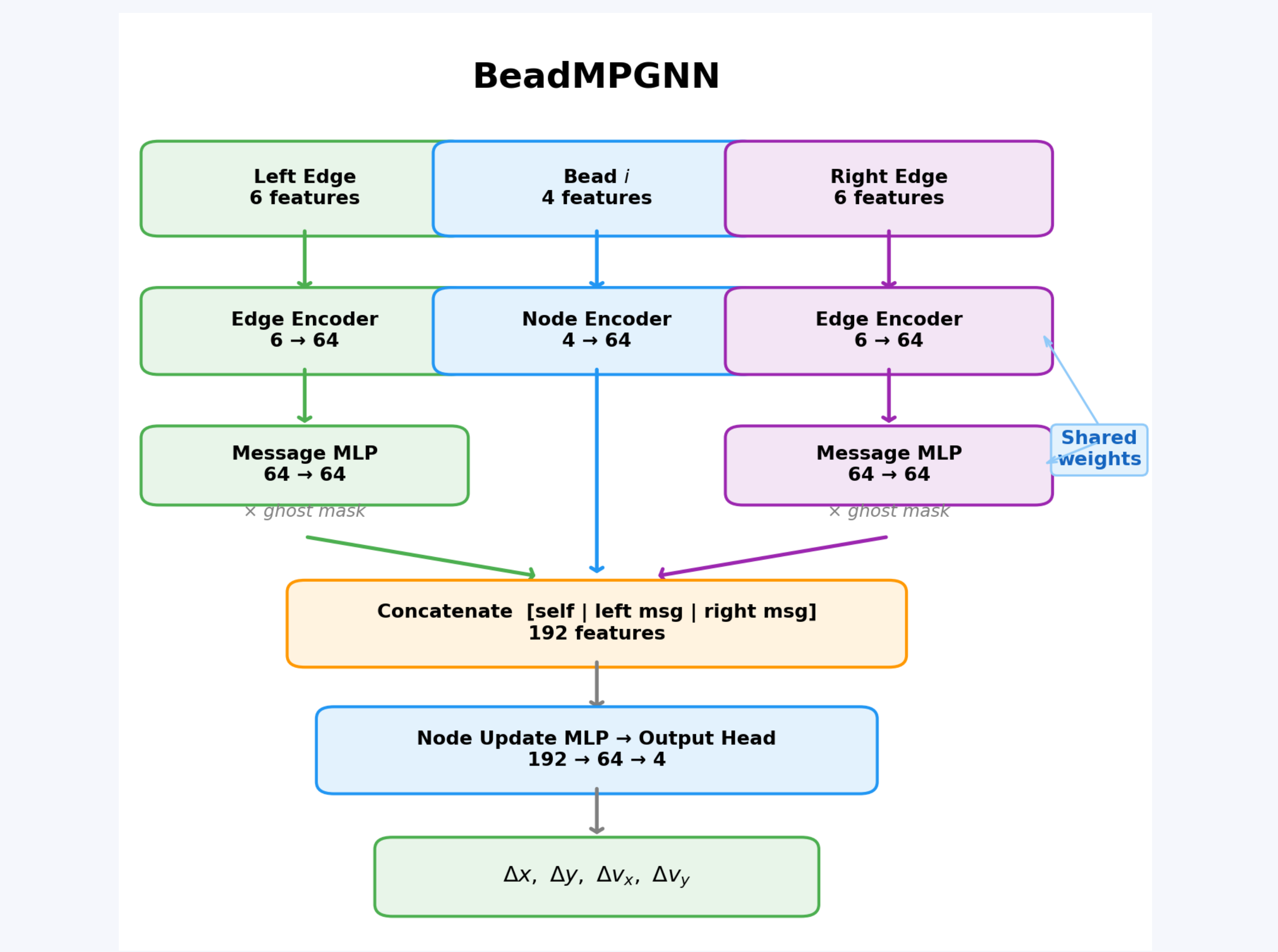
- **Node encoder** ($4 \rightarrow 64$): $[v_x, v_y, m, \text{fixed}]$
- **Edge encoder** ($6 \rightarrow 64$): shared left/right, relative features
- **Message MLP** ($64 \rightarrow 64$): per-edge learned message
- **Ghost mask**: zero messages from absent neighbors
- **Node update MLP** ($192 \rightarrow 64$): fuses self + messages
- **Output head** ($64 \rightarrow 4$): change in state

80,324 parameters, shared across all beads, independent of chain length.

Acknowledgements

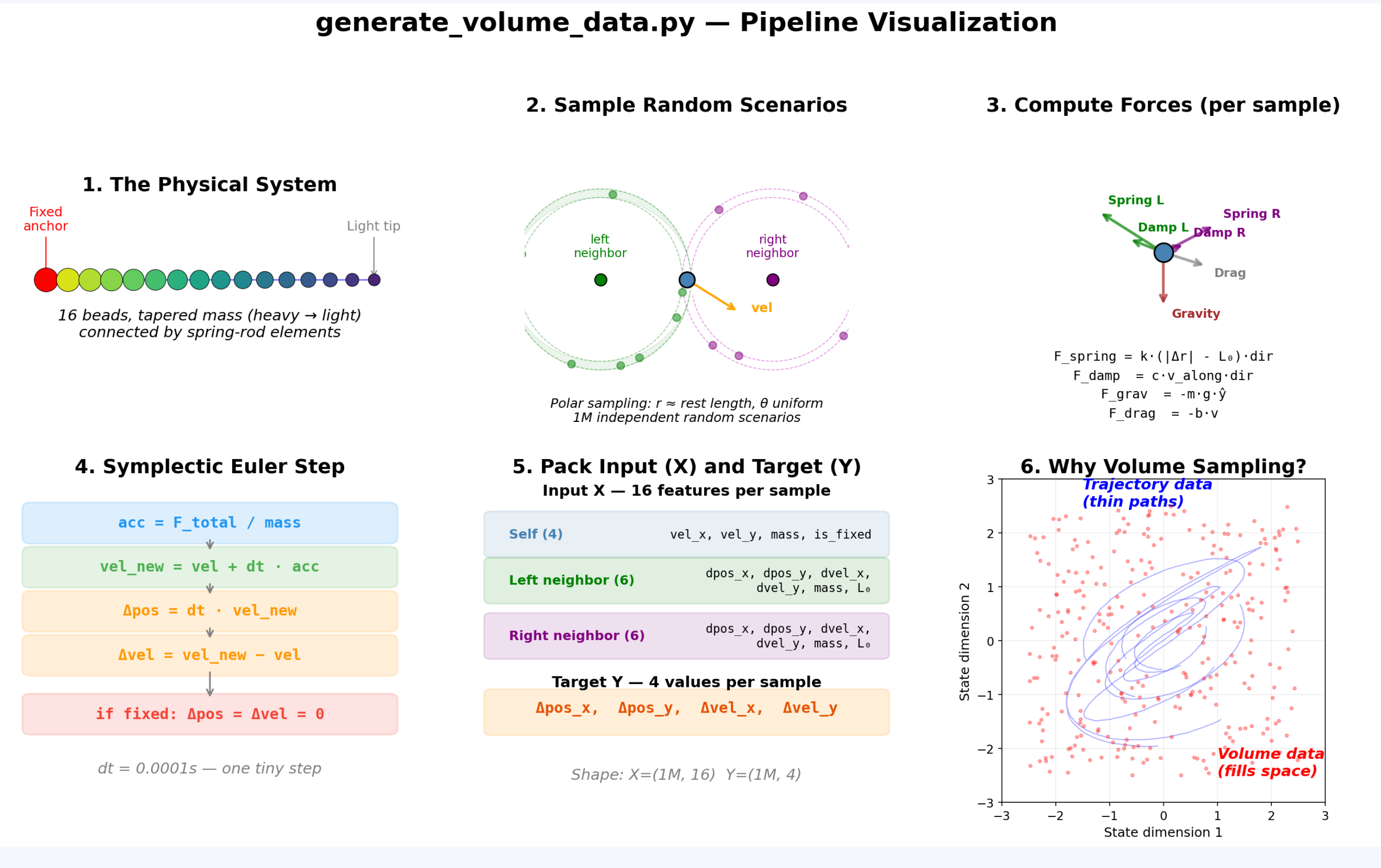
This work was supported in part by the National Science Foundation under Grants CCF 2230161 and 2230162 and in part by AFOSR under Grant FA9550-22-1-0362.

BeadMPGNN

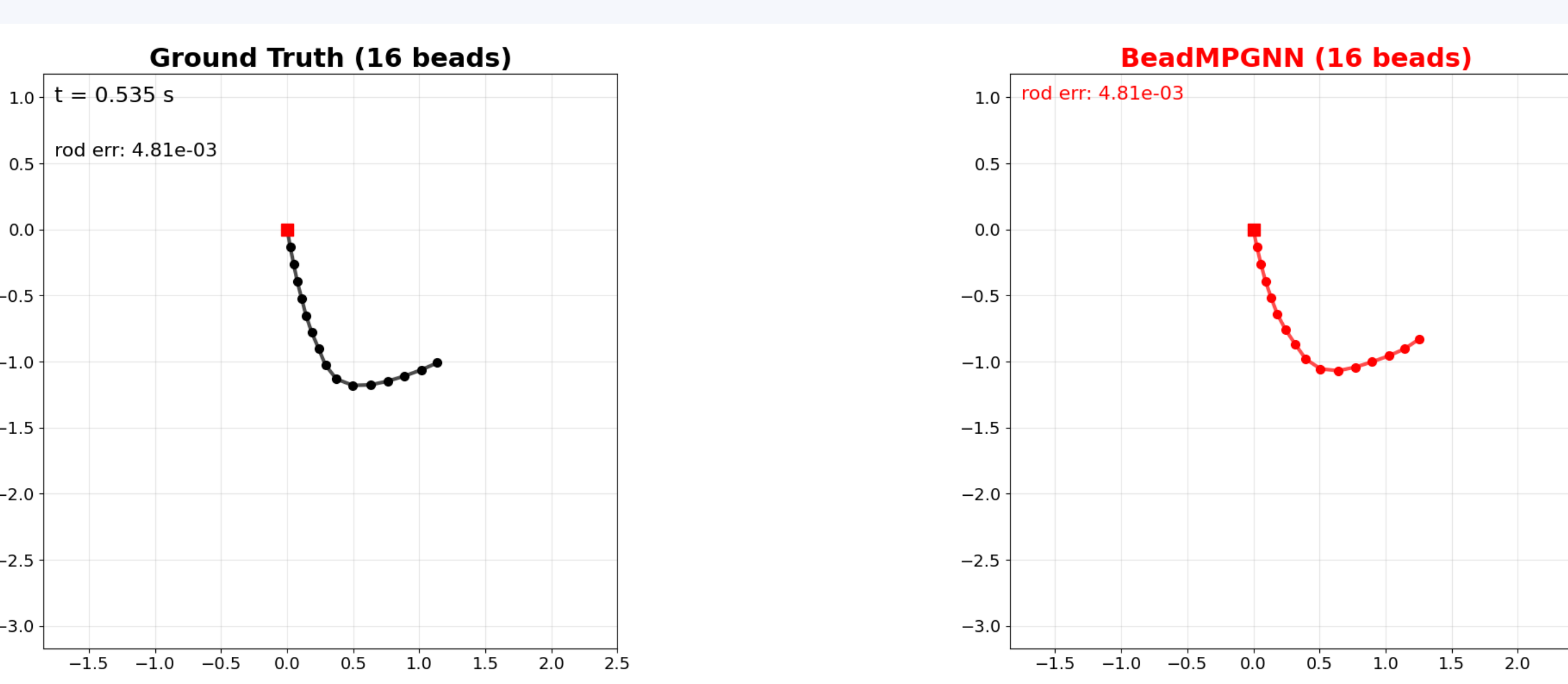


Data Pipeline: Volume Sampling

Rather than recording trajectories, we sample random single-step scenarios uniformly across the reachable state space. Each sample is one bead at one instant plus the exact physics result one timestep later. Volume sampling gives the model coverage across the full state space, not just along specific trajectories.



Side-by-Side Rollout



Ground truth (left, black) vs BeadMPGNN (right, red) on a 16-bead chain at $t = 0.535$ s.

Training Convergence



Generalization Across Chain Lengths

